

Episode 154: Long Ago... 92 1995 Part 12 My First Mac Experience in July

Last week I magnificently caught a cold, and the morning after writing my manuscript, my wife and I went to the neighbourhood doctor. Eh? Together? That's right! Actually, my wife suddenly developed a fever at night too, so we ended up going together as a couple.

Result: My wife magnificently hit influenza! I unfortunately (←eh?) missed. So well, we both ended up convalescing at home for about two days.

It's somehow subtle (laugh). A couple both resting with colds simultaneously (laugh). Quite restless feeling (laugh). First experience in 10 years of marriage. Thanks to that, we both recovered magnificently before the weekend.

...But wait? I've had a fever and cold symptoms again since yesterday. Huh? Hmm...
Anyway.

The September TV series *Neighbourhood Story*, which progressed parallel to theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?* production - after visiting original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei's workplace in May, we continued meetings with the teacher about twice weekly at Shueisha.

"Do you really meet with the original creator this much?" I was honestly surprised this time. Because in "manga-based" works I'd been involved with before, I'd never met with teachers this many times. Usually, original colour references were passed along with "use this as reference."

Maybe I just wasn't allowed to attend such meetings, and other works also had meetings with original creators at this frequency. But this time, both Seki-san and Umezawa-san made me keenly feel they valued my "colour design" (色彩設計) position. And I thought

Yazawa-sensei had that much expectation for the animation adaptation. Couldn't help feeling good pressure.

Regarding character colours, there were teacher's "rules" as I introduced last time (Episode 152), but we also received quite detailed, careful notes from Yazawa-sensei about other aspects. These were answers to questions from us animation production staff - points to note when drawing each character (like line uniformity and each character's proportional balance, clothing precautions, etc.), distance feelings in character relationships, motifs of the town serving as setting, floor plans of Mikako's apartment and layout diagrams of Yazagaku (Yazawa Arts Academy) where Mikako and others attend, plus sketches of important people scheduled to appear in future serialisation, and even overall story concepts about how she wanted to end the serialisation. Well, serialisation matters were naturally secret from outside.

After somehow finishing theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*~ by the end of June, I had no time to relax even for a moment and plunged into *Neighbourhood Story* work like a raging torrent. While working on slightly delayed character colour sample creation and colouring setting (彩色設定) production, preparing colour direction (色指定) for each episode. And some kind of meeting almost daily. By July 10th, we'd finished art meetings for Episodes 1 and 2.

Why it had become so hectic was because from July 12th, another week-long business trip to EEI-TOEI studio in Manila, Philippines was waiting. However, this trip was for *Neighbourhood Story*. Most in-betweening and finishing (仕上げ) and some backgrounds, plus some photography for *Neighbourhood Story* were decided to be handled at this Manila studio. If it were just normal in-betweening and finishing, probably no special meetings would be needed, but this time art and even photography work would be done at the Manila studio, so we should definitely have various discussions with local staff.

So this Manila trip was a large group. Series Director Umezawa-san, Art Directors Yuki-san and Gyo-san, and myself - the *Neighbourhood*~ crew. "If this plane crashes, *Neighbourhood Story* crashes too," was among the jokes (laugh).

The week-long business trip passed in a flash, and waiting for me upon return was poster work along with promotional stills. For posters, I'd finished colour direction (色指定) before the Manila trip, and I checked completed colouring the day after returning and delivered it. The problem was promotional stills - 2-3 points were finished in June, but the latter half additions were just starting meetings now. And among these was an order from the producer to "mix in things with computer image processing added."

"Hmm? Computer image processing? What should I do?" As mentioned earlier, one characteristic of Yazawa-sensei's works is slightly digital cuts and panels processed with computers, and the scheme was to show this a bit in *Neighbourhood Story* animation too.

Now, finally computers. Macintosh.

By this time, several sets of Apple Computer's PowerMacintosh 8100AV computers were already installed in Toei Animation's Oizumi Studio production department, arranged so anyone could basically use them. I've forgotten the detailed specs, but hard disc drives were still around 800MB, memory was maybe 32MB or 64MB? Compared to today's latest machines, they couldn't even enter the same arena, but they were still among the latest models then. At the end of May or beginning of June, something slightly beyond a "this is how you use it" workshop was held, and I'd been taught roughly the "basics" of usage, but actually was still far from ready. Even so, they definitely conveyed the atmosphere that "eventually everyone will become computerised."

The era was definitely heading digital, and actually, even home game consoles are digital computers, so work like painting cels with paint - while it wouldn't be just pushing buttons - would undoubtedly become computer work before long. So I needed to always prepare not to be left behind by such technology. This would definitely be a major turning point. Above all, since I'd been completely influenced by Director Yamauchi's Mac enthusiasm, "I really need to have my own Mac" was a natural progression. I thought I needed my own equipment to use freely. And I had a premonition I'd probably love computers.

And just before departing for Manila business trip, I made a big decision. Actually around this time, I left my parents' home, rented an apartment room calling it my "work room," and amazingly bought this PowerMacintosh 8100AV for that room.

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